Stable *or* Fluid?

You’re asking the wrong question.

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Independent Organizational Consultant & Coach





stable ≠ static

„*There are many reasons why* ***reasonably stable teams*** *perform better.*“

J. Richard Hackman, Leading Teams (2002)

Team Effectiveness Researcher

„Teams should be **stable but not static**, changing only occasionally and when necessary.“

Matthew Skelton & Manuel Pais, Team Topologies

„In essence, team change is inevitable, so we might as well get good at it.“

Heidi Helfand, Dynamic Reteaming



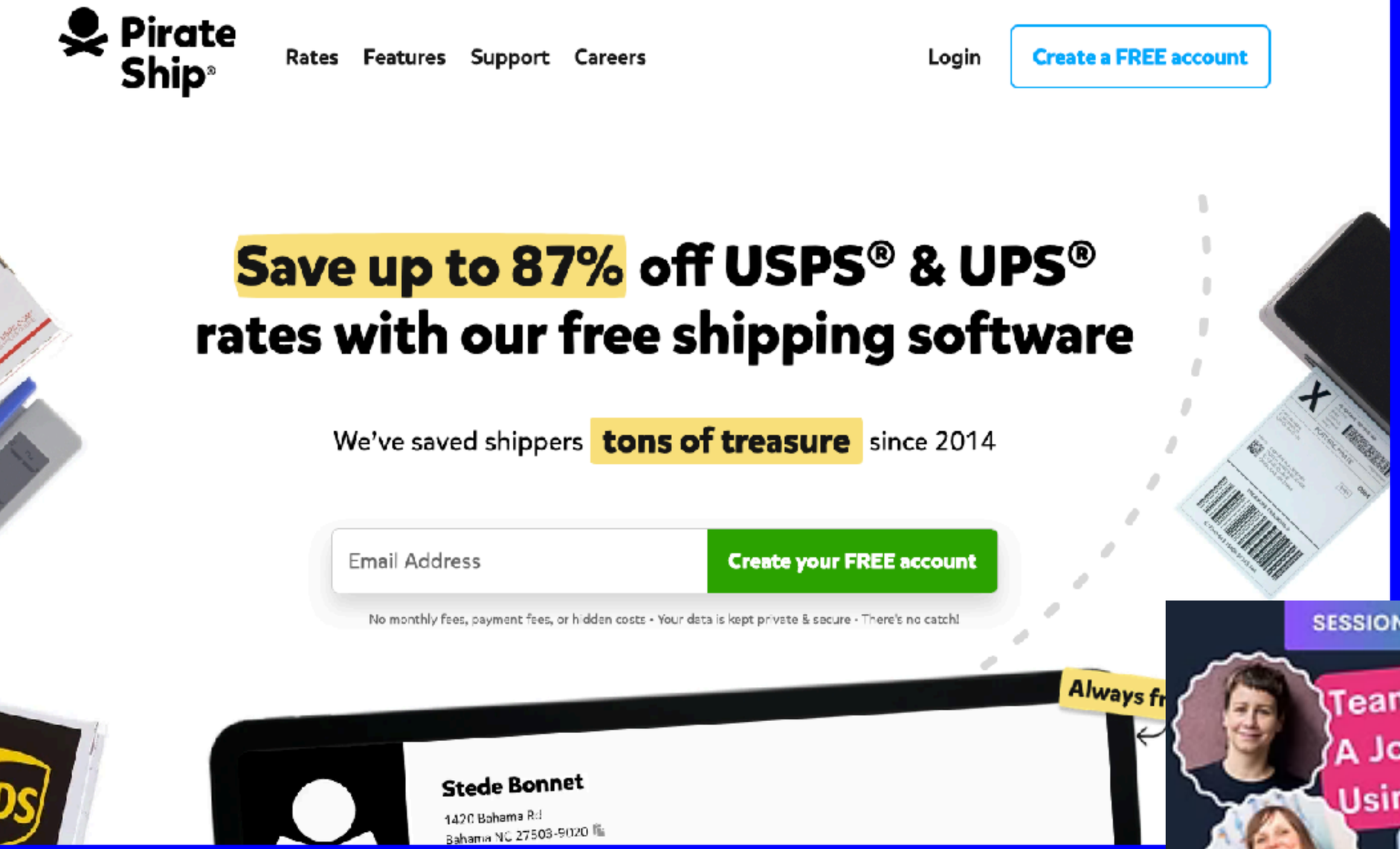
EXAMPLE 1

THOUGHT WORKS

The anchors



- Cross-functional teams
- Strong engineering practices
- Learning & Reflection routines
- Strong culture and values beyond the individual project





EXAMPLE 2

Pirate Ship Software


„Will we lose the
connection as we grow?“

Pirate Ship: the approach

1

Architecture for Flow

2

Teams shaped the new team structures

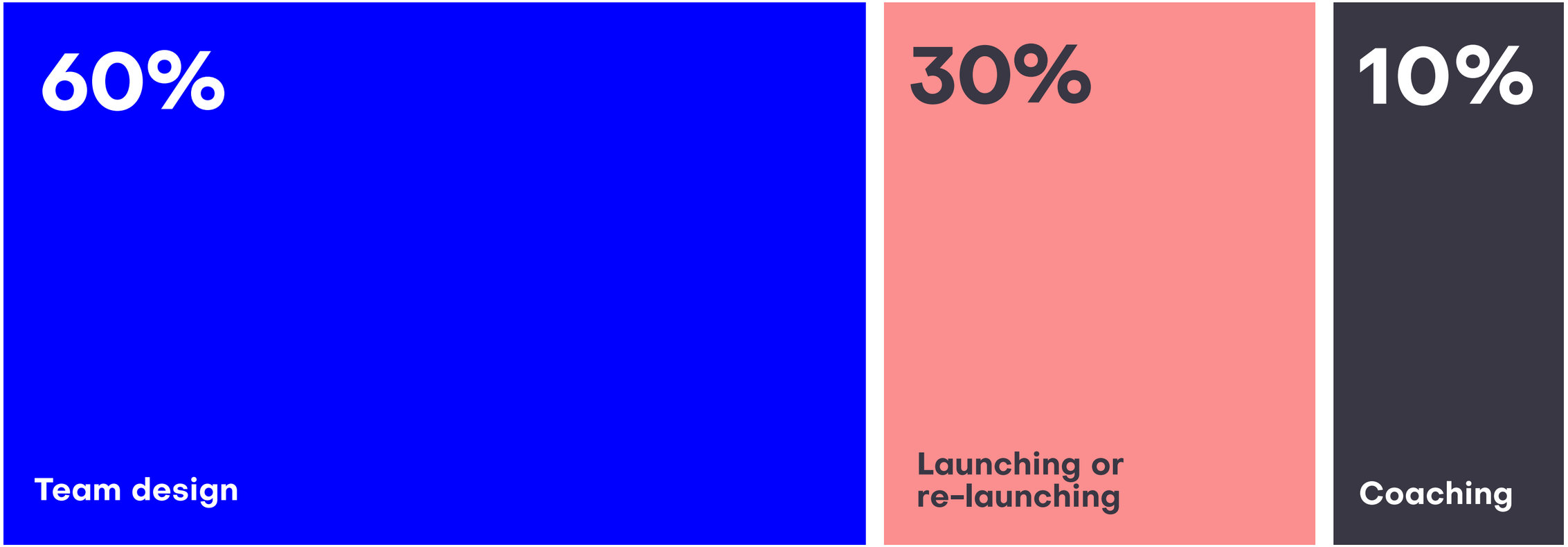
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Cell Division: Evolutionary Approach

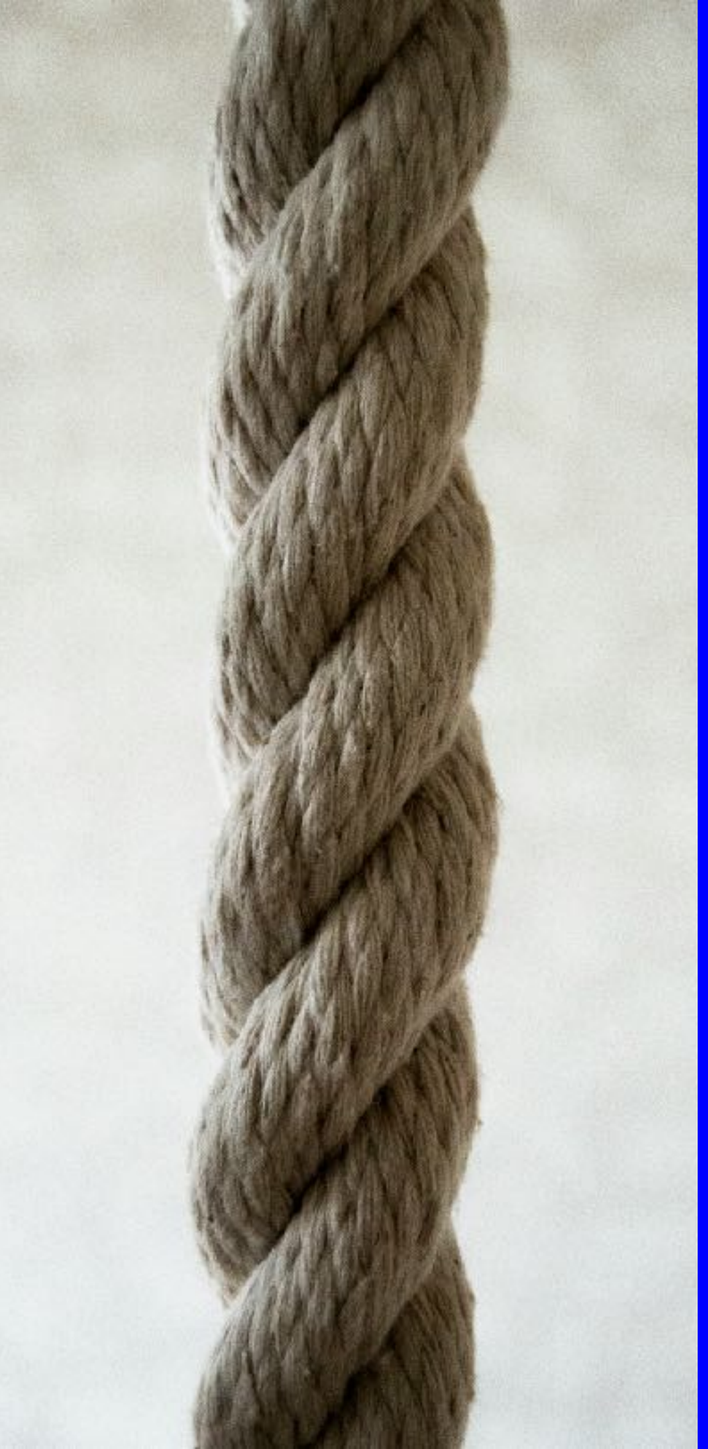
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Team structure evolved

Where should your energy go?



The 60-30-10 rule, Hackman & Wageman



Design for flow

so the work can flow

- **Boundaries that fit the domain**
- **Clear ownership**
- **Manageable cognitive load**

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e.g. **Architecture for Flow**

Learn to change

so people can handle change

- **Psychological safety**
- **Shared identity**
- **A say in change**
- **Learning routines**



Was it a decision?

	REACTIVE	INTENTIONAL
FLUID	**Necessity** Layoffs, budget cuts, forced reorgs	**Fluid by choice** Markets shift, exploring, spreading knowledge
STABLE	**Inertia** Nothing changes, even though it no longer works	**Stable by choice** Business as usual, complex systems, deep domain knowledge

Start small

1. Notice the warning signs
2. Explore bottlenecks and domains together
3. Involve the team in shaping the change
4. Reflect and learn after every change

1

Team change is a skill:

noticing when it’s needed, and handling it well, even when you didn’t choose it.

2

Change needs anchors

Is our team design still helping us deliver what matters right now?



Questions / Feedback?

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